

1 ENGROSSED SENATE
2 BILL NO. 710

By: Seifried of the Senate

3 and

4 Caldwell (Chad) of the
5 House

6 An Act relating to teacher preparation; amending
7 Section 1, Chapter 400, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp.
8 2025, Section 6-186.1), which relates to
9 establishment of TeachForwardOK; allowing the
10 Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability
11 to select more than one applicant to receive certain
12 monetary award if funds are sufficient; updating
13 statutory references; updating statutory language;
14 and declaring an emergency.

15 BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

16 SECTION 1. AMENDATORY Section 1, Chapter 400, O.S.L.
17 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 6-186.1), is amended to read as
18 follows:

19 Section 6-186.1. A. The Commission for Educational Quality and
20 Accountability shall establish and maintain a two-year pilot program
21 to be known as TeachForwardOK to provide new, high-quality pathways
22 to enter the teaching profession and increase the number of teachers
23 in this state's workforce.

24 B. Within thirty (30) days of ~~the effective date of this act~~
August 29, 2025, the Commission shall issue a request for proposals
to select technical assistance providers to evaluate teacher

1 education programs in institutions of higher education within The
2 Oklahoma State System of Higher Education that are accredited by the
3 Commission pursuant to Section 6-186 of ~~Title 70 of the Oklahoma~~
4 ~~Statutes~~ this title.

5 C. To participate in TeachForwardOK, a teacher education
6 program shall submit an application to the Commission in the manner
7 and on a form prescribed by the Commission. The Commission shall
8 establish criteria to approve applicants. Subject to the
9 availability of funds, the Commission shall award grants to approved
10 applicant teacher education programs. The Commission may use any
11 gifts, grants, devises, and donations from any public or private
12 source and monies appropriated by the Legislature for the purpose of
13 implementing the provisions of this section. Grants shall be used
14 as incentives to participate and to contract with a technical
15 assistance provider selected by the Commission pursuant to
16 subsection B of this section. The provider shall evaluate, at a
17 minimum, the following:

- 18 1. Teacher candidate recruitment and completion;
- 19 2. Whether the teacher education program prepares teacher
20 candidates effectively;
- 21 3. Whether the teacher education program meets workforce needs
22 in this state; and
- 23 4. Innovative ways to recruit nontraditional teacher candidates
24 unique to the teacher education program.

1 D. 1. Evaluation reports prepared by a technical assistance
2 provider shall be electronically submitted to the approved applicant
3 teacher education program and the Commission.

4 2. Within ninety (90) days of receiving the report, the teacher
5 education program shall electronically submit a report response to
6 the Commission detailing how the teacher education program plans to
7 address the evaluation report's findings. The report response shall
8 prioritize innovative approaches to provide new, high-quality
9 pathways to enter the teaching profession and increase the number of
10 teachers in this state's workforce including, but not limited to:

11 a. developing a system for recruiting eligible teacher
12 candidates, such as:

13 (1) a pathway for high school students to become
14 paraprofessionals,

15 (2) a pathway for paraprofessionals to become
16 teachers, and

17 (3) a pathway for individuals with bachelor's degrees
18 to become teachers,

19 b. developing a curriculum that includes intensive on-
20 the-job training for teacher candidates,

21 c. identifying a mastery-based evaluation system to
22 determine when eligible teacher candidates have
23 mastered the skills and competencies necessary for
24 graduation from an apprenticeship program and

- 1 outlining benchmarks that teacher candidates must meet
2 as they progress through on-the-job training,
- 3 d. offering a schedule that enables teacher candidates to
4 work ~~full-time~~ full-time in a public school district
5 while participating in an apprenticeship program and
6 allowing paraprofessionals to continue in their
7 positions, or
- 8 e. providing a flexible schedule for paraprofessionals
9 participating in an apprenticeship program to support
10 their success in the program that will facilitate
11 course completion and on-the-job training.

12 E. Subject to the availability of funding, the Commission shall
13 review the report responses submitted pursuant to subsection D of
14 this section and select one approved applicant teacher education
15 program to receive Five Hundred Thousand Dollars (\$500,000.00) to
16 enact the initiatives outlined in the program's report response. If
17 funds are sufficient, the Commission may select more than one
18 approved applicant teacher education program to receive a monetary
19 award based on the report response submitted pursuant to subsection
20 D of this section to enact the initiatives outlined in the report
21 response.

22 F. By December 31, 2027, the Commission shall electronically
23 submit a report of TeachForwardOK's findings and recommendations to
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1 the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, and the
2 Speaker of the House of Representatives.

3 G. The Commission shall promulgate rules to implement the
4 provisions of this section.

5 SECTION 2. It being immediately necessary for the preservation
6 of the public peace, health, or safety, an emergency is hereby
7 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and
8 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

9 Passed the Senate the 16th day of March, 2026.

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11 _____
12 Presiding Officer of the Senate

13 Passed the House of Representatives the ____ day of _____,
14 2026.

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17 Presiding Officer of the House
18 of Representatives
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